

SPORTS WORLD

By Harold U. Ribalow

Bit of Jewish Sports History In N. Y. Giants Story

When Horace Stoneham, president of the New York Giants, showed himself to be a baseball businessman rather than a sentimental fan by moving his team to San Francisco, a bit of Jewish sports history went along with him.

Reams of paper have been spent (or shall we say wasted) on the transfer of the Giants to the West Coast. Quite obviously, the Giant management played a poor second to the astute Yankee leaders who have kept the American League entry at the top of their circuit while the Giants went from bad to worse. Even with the brilliant Willie Mays, the National League team played to comparatively empty seats. Stoneham said that poor parking and indifferent patronage forced his move. He seemed unable to comprehend that the mediocre Giant teams drove away the old-time Giant fans and did little to win new ones.

Things used to be very different once upon a time. When John McGraw ran the giants, he had the most spectacular wheel in town. New York was a Giant town. And McGraw tried hard to bring a Jewish player to his club in order to gain additional fans. In the 1920's, the National Leaguers brought up Andy Cohen and for a while the Jewish followers of the sport made Andy one of the most popular Giants around. But Andy did not have the stuff to last. Besides, he had replaced Roger Hornsby, an authentic great, and when Andy slowed down in the field and hit less than .300 at the plate, his Giant days were numbered. Of course, Andy's .280 average looks good today, but it didn't please McGraw.

Danning and Arnovich

Later, there were other Jewish diamond stars with the Giants. Harry Danning was a fine catcher in Bill Terry's regime, and Phil Weintraub, a wonderful batter but less-than-average fielder, did lots of good work for the club. Morrie Arnovich also worked well for the team, as did Goody Rosen. But by far the most solid Jewish athlete to wear the Giant uniform

was Sid Gordon, who was both left-fielder and third-baseman for the Giants. Sid was a solid man, a long-ball hitter, and a guy who broke up many a game for his team. When he was traded away to Boston, the Giant management issued a special statement expressing the club's regret that it had been forced to lose the services of such an excellent athlete, but that it couldn't make an important trade unless Gordon were included. Oddly, Sid's days were numbered after he shed the Giant uniform.

But there is more to the Giants leaving than remembering the Jewish stars who cavorted on the Polo Grounds baseball field. To more than one Jewish youngster who fell in love with baseball, the Giants were important in another sense as well. They represented America, with the memories of Matty and Mel Ott (who was playing out the string in those days) and Carl Hubbell and Jo-Jo Moore and Fred Fitzmonns and Hughie Critz. One took to these players and one felt that one was more of an American in following their fortunes. Our parents accepted that we were different and that we were interested in something they could not fathom. To this writer, it was the Polo Grounds, not Yankee Stadium or Ebbets Field.

They Were Good Days

The first game we saw at the Polo Grounds was late in 1933, after the Giants already had clinched the pennant. They were opposing the Braves, then of Boston and not Milwaukee. Ed Brandt pitched for Boston and he was a tough left-hander. The Giant pitcher was Hubbell. Phil Weintraub was then a Giant outfielder and we recall how he followed his every gesture. Hubbell pitched a four hitter and won 2-1. The Giant team included, besides Weintraub, Sam Leslie (who replaced after the flag was won, the great Bill Terry), Hugh Critz, Blondie Ryan and Johnny Vergez. Gus Mancuso caught and we remember wondering why Harry Danning wasn't given a chance.